

Your First Ten Minutes With Claude

You've been hearing about this for two years now. Maybe you tried it once, typed "hello," got back a wall of text, and quietly closed the tab. Maybe you've been waiting for a reason.

This takes ten minutes. It costs nothing.

And at the end you'll have one real thing — not a demo, not a tour of the features. Something you actually made, that you'd be happy to show someone.

That's the whole promise.

TEN MINUTES. ONE THING. START WHERE YOU ARE.

01

Where to go, and what you'll see

Open a browser and go to **claude.ai**

Make an account. An email address works. So does signing in with a Google or Apple account you already have. There's a free version, and it's the one you want — you don't need to pay anything to do what's in this guide.

There's nothing to install.

Once you're in, the screen will look mostly empty. That's not a mistake, and you haven't missed a step. There's a wide box near the bottom with a cursor blinking in it, waiting for you.

That box is the whole thing. Everything in this guide happens there.

ON YOUR PHONE INSTEAD?

The Claude app works exactly the same way — same account, same conversations, whichever one you pick up.

02

Type this

Here's your first message. Type it, or copy it word for word:

TYPE THIS IN

I need to send a message to someone and I'm not sure how to word it. It's a bit awkward. Ask me a few questions about the situation first, then help me write it.

Then press enter.

Now the important part: it's going to ask you questions.

Answer them the way you'd answer a friend who asked. Short is fine. Messy is fine. You don't have to write well here — that's the entire point.

When it gives you a draft, tell it what's off. *Warmer. Shorter. Less formal. That last line is too much.*

It'll try again. Do that two or three times, until the message sounds like you.

03

What just happened

You didn't learn a system. You had a conversation.

Notice what it did: **it asked before it answered**. That happened because you told it to. Most people type four words, get something generic back, and decide this isn't for them. The difference between a generic answer and a good one is almost always how much you said first.

THREE THINGS WORTH CARRYING FORWARD

It knows nothing about you until you tell it. It isn't holding back. It genuinely doesn't know your situation, your history, or how you talk.

The first answer is a draft, not a verdict. Saying “shorter” takes two seconds and usually works better than starting over.

You can't break it. Typos, half-finished thoughts, changing your mind halfway — all fine. There is no wrong way to type here.

04

Now do it with your own

Pick something small that's genuinely on your plate today. Then say what you want the way you'd say it out loud.

REAL ONES TO START FROM

I got a letter I don't fully understand. I'm going to paste it in below. Tell me what it actually says and whether I need to do anything about it.

I have chicken, half a bag of spinach, and some rice in the kitchen and no plan for dinner. Give me three options.

Help me write a thank-you note that doesn't sound like a form letter.

Explain how this works like I've never done it before, one step at a time.

If the answer isn't right, say so and ask again. That isn't the tool failing. That's the tool working.

If that was useful

If the only thing you ever do with this is get help wording a difficult message, that was ten minutes well spent. You don't owe it any more of your time than that.

IF YOU WANT TO GO FURTHER

Claude for Absolute Beginners

The account, the screen, the handful of habits that make it work, and an honest account of what it's good for.

Is This Safe?

What it can and can't see, why it's sometimes wrong, and the short list of things you should never type in.

101 Everyday Things to Ask Claude

Open to any page, find something worth trying today.

ONE HONEST NOTE BEFORE YOU GO

It can be wrong, and it won't sound wrong — it writes with the same confidence either way. For anything that really matters, use it to understand and prepare, then confirm with a person who knows. Money, health, legal, and anything you can't undo: always check.

The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.
